

Topics in Metaphysics: Time and Modality

Cian Dorr

5th February 2015

1 The A-theory/B-theory debate

<i>The A-theory of time</i>	<i>The B-theory of time</i>
The present time is “metaphysically special”, “privileged”, “distinguished”.	All times are “on a par”.
There are facts about which times are past, present and future, over and above the facts about which times are before which.	There are no such further facts. Pastness, presentness and futurity “reduce” to before-ness and afterness.
Time genuinely “flows” and “passes”. There is “objective becoming”.	Reality is a “block universe”.
The facts themselves change.	Change is just a certain kind of pattern in the facts.

2 Our two questions

- T1 Are there temporarily true propositions?
Propositional temporalism: yes. *Propositional eternalism*: no.
- T2 Is the unit class of the present instant much more natural than the unit classes of most other instants?
Temporal elitism: yes. *Temporal egalitarianism*: no.

But are there not thoughts which are true today but false in six months time? The thought, for example, that the tree there is covered with green leaves, will surely be false in six months time. No, for it is not the same thought at all. The words ‘This tree is covered with green leaves’ are not sufficient by themselves for the utterance, the time of utterance is involved as well. Without the time-indication this gives we have no complete thought, i.e. no thought at all. Only a sentence supplemented by a time-indication and complete in every respect expresses a thought. But this, if it is true, is true not only today or tomorrow but timelessly. (Frege, ‘The Thought’.)

(Truth schema) The proposition that ϕ is such that for it to be true is for it to be the case that ϕ .

(Belief Schema) The proposition that ϕ is such that to believe it is to believe that ϕ .

Discussion of the formulation of T2:

- Why ‘most’?
- Worry about catching the B-theorist at the wrong time.
- Why not use natural *properties* rather than natural *classes*?

3 Arguments that the questions should be answered in the same way

t is accurate $=_df$ the propositions true at t are all and only the true propositions.

4 Modal analogues

- M1 Are there contingently true propositions?
Propositional contingentism: yes. *Propositional necessitism*: no.

M2 Is the unit class of the actual world much more natural than the unit classes of most other possible worlds?

Modal elitism: yes. Modal egalitarianism: no.

Warning: We will need to get very clear on what the ‘possible world’ role is, to make sure that we don’t misclassify people who just use the expression ‘possible world’ in an eccentric way as modal egalitarians. (We have to be especially careful with Lewis!) This also applies to ‘instant’.

5 The primordial objection to egalitarianism

6 Other analogues: places and people

7 Other themes in the A-theory/B-theory debate

- Objectivity versus subjectivity of past, present, future
- Absoluteness versus relativity of past, present, future
- Irreducibility versus reducibility of past, present, future
- Flow and passage

The standard realist [roughly: the propositional temporalist temporal elitist] faces a general difficulty. For suppose we ask: given a complete tenseless description of reality, then what does he need to add to the description to render it complete by his own lights? The answer is that he need add nothing beyond the fact that a given time t is present, since everything else of tense-theoretic interest will follow from this fact and the tenseless facts. But then how could this solitary ‘dynamic’ fact, in addition to the static facts that the antirealist is willing to accept, be sufficient to account for the passage of time? [The realist’s] conception of temporal reality. . . is as static or block-like as the anti-realist’s, the only difference lying in the fact that his block has a privileged center. Even if presentness is allowed to shed its light upon the world, there is nothing in his metaphysics to prevent that light being ‘frozen’ on a particular moment of time. (Kit Fine, ‘Tense and Reality’.)